



DEEP STRIPES
Still from *Flying Tigers*; (below) Madhusree Dutta

FILM

Memory's Hidden Tigers

IN *FLYING TIGERS*, **MADHUSREE DUTTA** TRACES HER MOTHER'S HAUNTING CHILDHOOD MEMORY TO A FORGOTTEN WW-II OPERATION THAT FOREVER ALTERED LIVES IN ASSAM

"Close the windows. The tiger is coming." A mother's urgent warning sets *Flying Tigers* in motion. When Alzheimer's dredges up a fragment of her mother's childhood, National Award–winning filmmaker Madhusree Dutta begins following its trail. The search led her to 1940s Assam, where the United States had established a perilous aerial supply route over the Himalayas to transport military aid to China during World War II. The vast wartime operation reshaped forests and tea plantations, disrupting fragile ecologies. Tigers, forced out of their habitats, started straying into human settlements.

Flying Tigers, which premiered at the 76th Berlinale, marks Dutta's return to filmmaking after 20 years. It unfolds as a layered, genre-blurring essay that moves between Assam and China alongside Kunming-born media scholar Mi You and Assamese writer Purav Goswami. Together, the trio piece through archival fragments, conversations, letters, uncovering a shared past between two nations now divided by militarised borders.

In her prolific career, Dutta has largely engaged with urban cultures, feminist narratives and postcolonial identities. Her turn toward this subject began in 2015, when her mother, shortly before her death, recalled tigers attacking their home. The image lingered. "As I kept thinking about it," Dutta says, "I became drawn to memory—personal and cultural—how it survives, shifts contour...unexpectedly resurfaces."

Shot by Riju Das, Isabelle Casez and Guligo Jia Yanan, the cinematography mirrors the film's fluid structure, allowing landscape and memory to blur. In Dutta's hands, illness becomes an archive, and personal memory opens onto a meditation on war, infrastructure and the landscapes that continue to carry their imprint. ■

—Poulomi Das

FILM

REALITY BITES

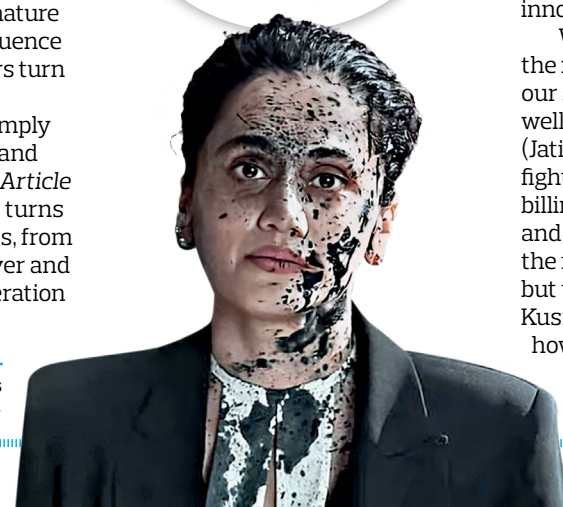
Anubhav Sinha's *Assi* puts the focus on the brutality of rape and the devastation it leaves behind

Anubhav Sinha's latest social drama doesn't waste time in establishing why he opted for the title. *Assi* (80) is the number of women who are sexually assaulted in India every 20 minutes; it's also the figure that's heard in the car which drives around the capital one night as four men rape a woman (Kani Kusruti). Sinha is in no mood to spare the audiences from the harrowing nature of the crime, prolonging the sequence to a degree that it makes viewers turn their eyes away.

The drama, though, is not simply about finding the perpetrators and seeking justice. Along with his *Article 15* writer Gaurav Solanki, Sinha turns his attention to a range of issues, from the survivor's struggle to recover and readjust to society to the desperation of an assailant's parent (Manoj Pahwa) to save his son from prison. The gravity of the incident is also not a deterrent for the makers in showing the unfolding chaos from the perspective of the survivor's child. "Why bring a child to court?" asks a lawyer to the father (Mohd Zeeshan Ayyub). He responds saying the incident's aftermath has erased the kid's innocence altogether.

When it comes to highlighting the moral ambiguities that plague our society, Sinha and Solanki do well with the inclusion of a cop (Jatin Goswami) who fights the good fight, often alone. Pannu gets top billing here as the victim's lawyer and is the main vehicle to deliver the film's hard-hitting message, but the soul and spine of the film is Kusruti, who affectively conveys how deep the scars run in the screen time she's afforded. ■

—SS



Taapsee Pannu as the rape victim's lawyer, Raavi, in *Assi* »